How a large IT organisation delivered more projects by cutting governance planning time by 65%

A service design case study

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Role: Service Designer
Sector: Higher Education
Duration: 5 months



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Improving project delivery by co-creating a digital portal and triage forum

THE BRIEF

A large university IT department wanted better governance to deliver more projects and a more delightful delivery experience. Stakeholders found it confusing, costly and slow.

THE DISCOVERY

Interviews and workshops revealed three problem areas that had to be addressed: one-size-fits-all rules, no central entry point and poor coordination across governance domains.

THE SOLUTION

Governance owners and project team members co-created a digital portal and triage forum, then tested them on real projects. Both sides reported delivering more and higher-quality projects.

65%

estimated reduction in time to plan governance at the start of a project.

1 week from brief to the next triage forum, vs a 3-week benchmark.

THE TAKEAWAY

When many actors shape a service, the biggest gains come from coordinating them.

DISCOVERY

Project teams struggled at project start without a single entry point or coordination across governance domains

THE APPROACH

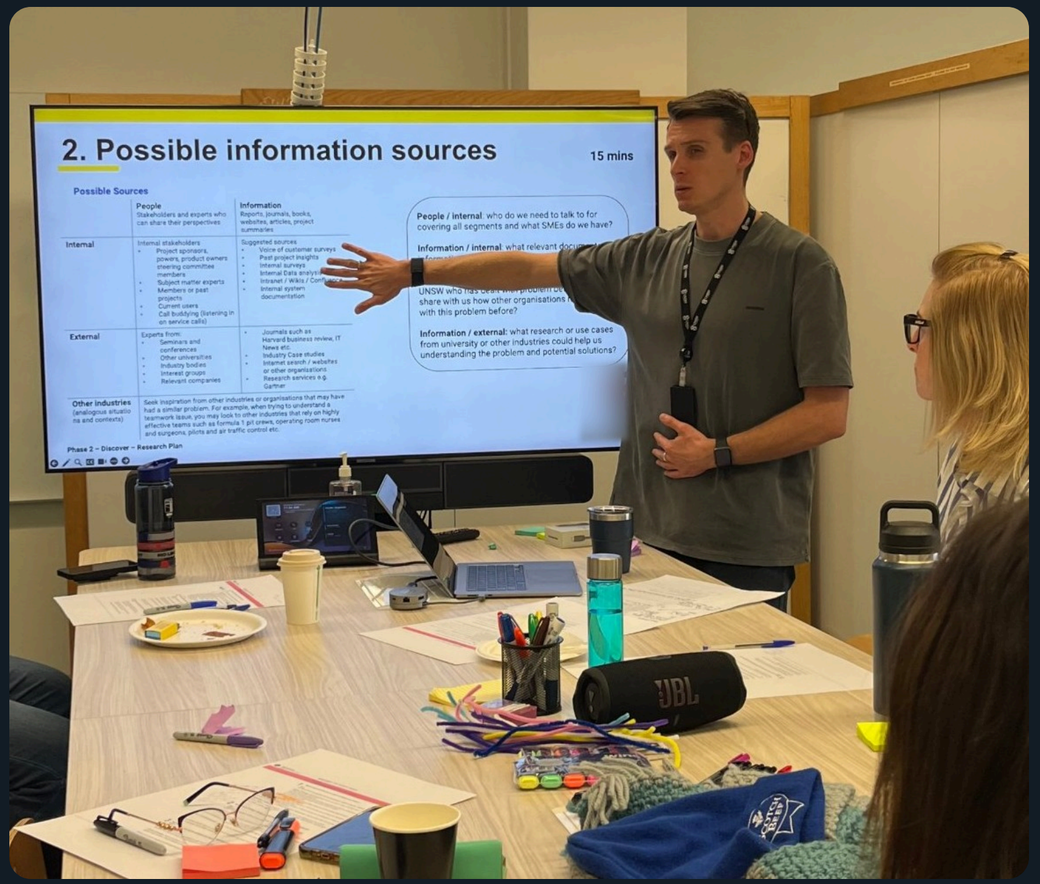
The project started by empathising with stakeholders across the IT governance system through interviews, process mapping and workshops, so solutioning would solve the right problems.

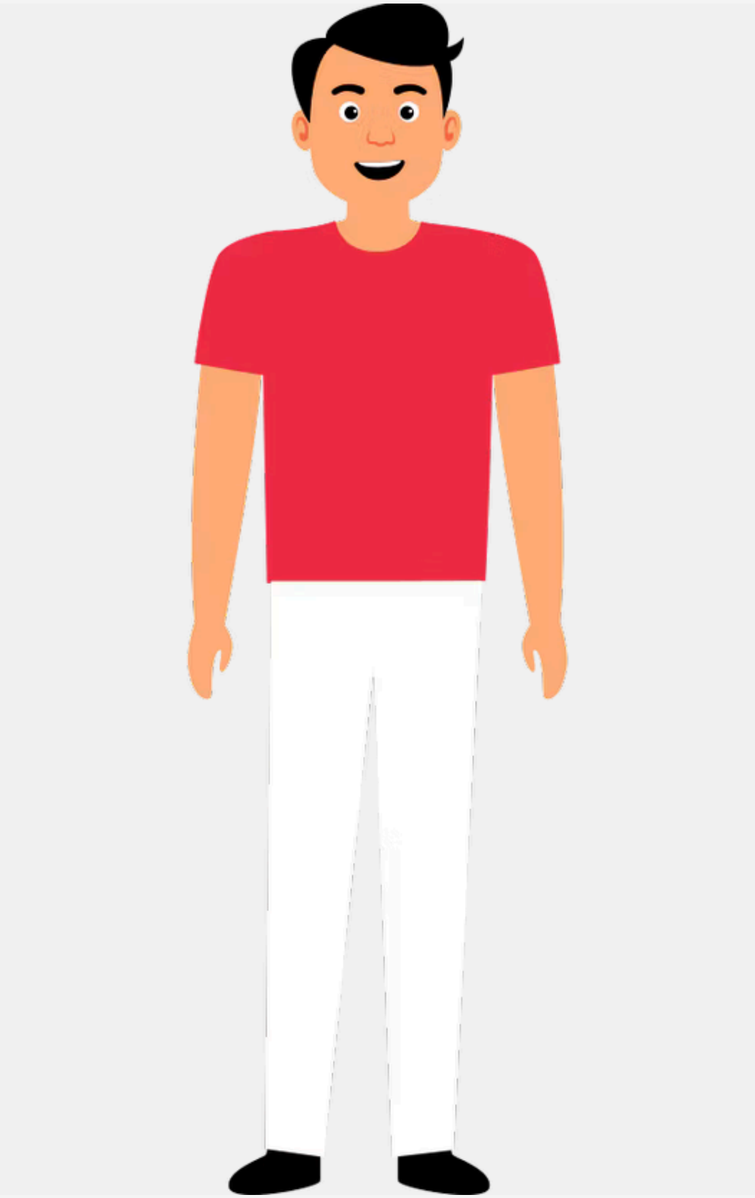
THE OUTPUT

Two personas (Alex, a project manager, and Jane, a governance owner), process maps and a journey map showing where governance failed project teams.

THE INSIGHT

Confusion and long lead times came from one-size-fits-all governance, no central entry point and poor coordination across domains. Problems peaked at project start, so the remainder of the project focused there.





PERSONA 1

Alex

Leads projects through most of the compliance checks and is the main contact for the business customer.

PROFILE

Roles
Program Manager
Project Manager
Tech Manager

Team
IT delivery

Experience
Varies

Tech literacy
Medium

WANTS & NEEDS

- One clear place to start governance
- Clear guidance on what to deliver when to whom
- Effort in proportion to the project
- Fewer separate conversations

FRUSTRATIONS

- Nine governance domains to manage
- Same hoops for every project size
- Lead time and cost out of proportion
- Decisions relitigated
- Jargon he doesn't understand



PERSONA 2

Jane

Owns one of nine governance domains, such as cybersecurity or data, and is responsible for compliance.

PROFILE

Role	Team	Experience	Tech literacy
Governance owner	**IT / Data / Legal**	**Expert**	**High**

WANTS & NEEDS

- Audit trail to show to auditors
- Projects that arrive prepared
- Reassurance of compliance

FRUSTRATIONS

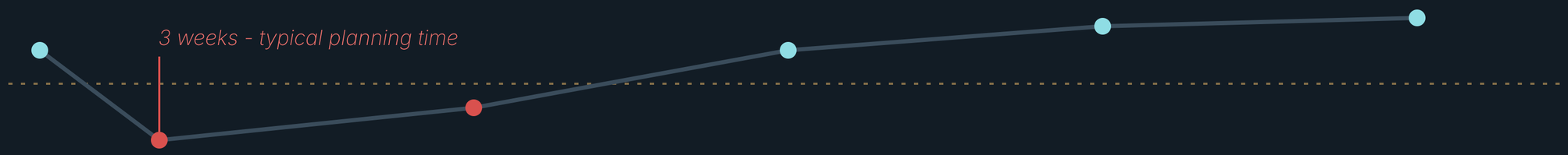
- Limited or incorrect compliance evidence
- Projects arrive late or not at all
- Little time for governance work
- Being negatively perceived



DISCOVERY · JOURNEY MAP

Alex's governance journey

	Concept	Initiate	Define	Deliver	Closure
	Informal team works out governance with no budget and no entry point.	Project managers take over and engage nine governance domains one by one.	Formal project team is established, including SteerCo, and they start planning project delivery.	Governance is settled and the team focuses on delivery.	The initiative is handed over and closed.
Touchpoints	• PMO SMEs • SharePoint sites • Email contact with governance owners	• Email / Teams calls with governance owners	• Governance owners • Governance forms • SteerCo	• Project reporting • SteerCo	• Governance forms
Emotion					
Positive					
Negative					
Quotes	*"Now we have to figure out how to get this through governance."* *"Why does it take so long to get through governance at this stage?"*	*"Didn't we settle this already? Where do I go next?"* *"I often go around in circles without going anywhere."*	*"Once we're in define and deliver, things start to go smoothly and we know what to do."*		



SOLUTIONING

Co-creating one digital entry point to cut planning time by an estimated 65%

IDEATION

Governance owners and project team members came together in a workshop. The main conclusion was to create and test a single entry point at project start that gives each project a right-sized governance pathway.

PROTOTYPING & TESTING

The project continued by translating workshop conclusions into a future-state service blueprint, prototyping the portal and triage forum, and finally testing them on real projects.

THE RESULT

Testing showed that project team members struggled to use the initiative brief. After revising the form, usability improved and stakeholders said the portal and triage forum cut planning time by 65% and governance was better tailored to projects.





SERVICE BLUEPRINT

Target state governance system

	Concept	Initiate	Define	Deliver	Closure
Physical evidence	Digital portal: initiative brief; right-sized governance map	Compliance templates; digital portal; compliance-check notifications			Digital portal: closure report
Project team actions	Submits initiative brief through the portal	Requests support from governance owners when needed and provides compliance evidence through the portal.			Writes closure report and submits through portal
					line of interaction
Onstage	Triage forum provides a right-sized governance map.	Governance teams support project team members with navigating policies and regulation where needed. Digital portal shows status of compliance checks and feedback on compliance evidence.			—
					line of visibility
Backstage	Owners assess the brief before triage; system creates governance case file.	Governance owners check the evidence provided and decisions across domains in the portal. Portal system updates governance case file when a decision is made or status changed.			Governance owners (PMO) review closure report; project and case file closed.
					line of internal interaction
Support	Digital governance portal, incl. living governance case file				
	Continuous coordination and improvement across governance domains to ensure appropriate process sequencing across nine governance domains				
	Policies and regulation				

1 week

OUTCOMES

Cutting governance planning time by an estimated 65% helped teams deliver more projects with less friction

65%

estimated reduction in time to determine and plan governance activities at the start of a project

1 week

from brief in the digital portal to the next triage forum, compared with a benchmark of 3 weeks

WHAT CHANGED

A single digital entry point

The digital portal and initiative brief.

Increased coordination

Between governance domains, through a triage forum.

Right-sized governance pathways

The output of the triage forum.

CONCLUSION

Better service experiences come from breaking down silos, looking beyond single fixes and co-creating solutions

INTER-ORGANISATIONAL COORDINATION

Optimising within one domain does not give a consistent service experience. Here, project team members had to coordinate the governance domains themselves, at the cost of their service experience.

TECHNOLOGY, PROCESS AND PEOPLE

Better service experience took both technology and process redesign: a digital portal and a triage forum that increased coordination across governance owners.

A CO-CREATIVE DESIGN APPROACH

Co-creative workshops were essential. Productive solutioning began once key stakeholder groups built mutual empathy.

